To what extent did the reforms established by Marcello Caetano weaken the Estado Novo regime in Portugal?

(1968-1970)

Academic research by
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Section 1: Identification and Evaluation of Sources

This investigation aims to examine the extent to the reforms established by Marcello Caetano, were a weakening factor for Estado Novo. This study will focus on the period between 1968 and 1970, best known as “Primavera Marcelista” (Marcelist Spring) considered by many, one of the periods in Estado Novo with the greatest development. This period and the research question seem to me as the best suited one for the purpose of this investigation.

The first source is Estado Novo (História de Portugal) by Fernando Rosas. Regarding the origin, this book is extremely valuable to the investigation for the author took a master’s degree in history of XIX and XX centuries, the period of this investigation. Thus, as Rosas is writing a book in his area of expertise the information that it contains can be considered, to a certain degree, trustworthy. Furthermore, Fernando Rosas was an adult when Marcello Caetano, reached the power, hence, he lived and was able to eyewitness these reforms. Nevertheless, these can be a limitation, as the author might be influenced by his former experiences, therefore the book may be permeable to some bias. Furthermore, another limitation that the origin may present to the investigation is the author’s association with left wing parties, the PCP[1] or the CDE[2], for instance, (he was even arrested by the PIDE[3] for this association) therefore he might expose a biased perspective of Estado novo.

[1] Portuguese Communist Party
[2] Electoral Democratic Commission
[3] Political Police

Regarding the purpose of Rosas' book, it adds value to the investigation because the aim of the book is solely analyse Estado, hence the author has more room to provide detailed information, about the regime.

The origin of the second source, História de Portugal by Rui Ramos, is quite valuable, as Rui Ramos like Fernando focused his studies on the XIX and the XX centuries, thus he is also in is domain of expertise, and he was also born in Estado Novo, meaning that he, like Rosas, eyewitnessed these reforms. Furthermore, although, from reading the book, I believe that Ramos approaches Estado Novo objectively, it might be permeable to national bias, as the author seems to be slightly sympathetic to Estado Novo, at least does not give such pejorative view as other authors. Although this can be a limitation, it may also be valuable as it brings different perspectives to my investigation.

The purpose of the second source may also provide significant value to my investigation, as, although the book explores all the History of Portugal, it has a chapter solely to explore the Marcelism.

Section 2: Investigation

2.I: Context

Estado Novo was, to some extent, economically fruitful for Portugal, the country's economy was no longer primarily agrarian and became, in part, industrial. As always, society's structure mirrored the economy's behaviour. Like José Hermano wrote "The structure of the population changed."[4] Now, the economic activity was, to some degree, evenly distributed through the different sectors of society and a middle class was forming ("In 1970 for, activities from the primary sector, as a whole, occupied 31%; the industry, 34%; the services, about 35%.")[5]

However, despite the economic improvement, many people from the middle classes, who were "the main beneficiary of the economic transformation"[6], were now dissatisfied, as this economic improvement was, in part, achieved through freedom constrains. However according to Hermano "The restrictions to political rights, were once wished and then tolerated by an middle class with agrarian roots in a phase of economic depression (who saw in the constrains an order policy), started to be felt as unbearable impositions by the new industrial and commercial middle class in a phase of expansion."[7] The truth was, that the support for Estado Novo was in decline, also due to a political neglect, for example, the União Nacional[8] which intended to "include anyone who wanted to intervene in political activities… but due to many years without electoral acts

[4] Saraiva, J. H. (2003). História Concisa de Portugal. Europa-América. (p.245)
[5] Saraiva, J. H. (2003). História Concisa de Portugal. Europa-América. (p.243)
[6] Saraiva, J. H. (2003). História Concisa de Portugal. Europa-América. (p.244)
[7] Saraiva, J. H. (2003). História Concisa de Portugal. Europa-América. (p.243)
[8] National Union

made it quickly decline in a feeble situation, without any political vitality"[9]

When Salazar died Marcello Caetano was appointed as the "obvious candidate" [10] to the position. When the Law Professor took his place on September 23, 1968, he found an economically stable country, but a regime losing support before his eyes. Something had to change.

2.II: Did Marcello Caetano's reforms weaken Estado Novo?

The "Marcelistic Spring" (1968-1970), already referred in the section 1, was the period where these reforms were applied. The reforms were dismissed after 1970 due to some factors that will be analysed later in the investigation.

It was expected of Marcello Caetano to bring change to the regime: approximation to Europe, solve Portugal's political stagnation and the colonial war. These hopes were in part, based on his criticism to his predecessor's policies ("disagreed with almost everything that has been done"[11]), and on José Melo Castro's (President of UN executive commission) promise to approximate the regime to the Western European models.

However, the reforms that would supposedly be the carrier of this change, were endangered due to the condition imposed to Marcello's election as president: of not touch on the colonial war, which he felt forced to compel, despite its vanity[12].

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[9] Saraiva, J. H. (2003). História Concisa de Portugal. Europa-América. (p. 244).
[10] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.484).
[11] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. Esfera dos Livros. (p. 696).
[12] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.485).

Ramos and Rosas, hold that Marcello knew that losing the colonies was inevitable and so losing control. Nevertheless, he will continue it; to buy time to make a gradual evolution.

To start these reforms, “Active political frameworks well doctrine and collaborative media”[13] were needed. To meet these conditions, Caetano will arrange the most favourable political scenario for himself: in the highest positions, his political friends will be placed to secure his position; a step down, he will place the liberals to support his reforms; the Ultras will be used as counterweight, to protect the dictatorship.[14]

Nevertheless, the approximation to the western European models was subtle, as Ramos believed, that Marcello feared that democratization would strengthen the opposition[15]. Rosas, on the other hand, believed that Marcelism was a reformist triumph, while acknowledging that he was no liberal[16]. Note that, for Rosas, the reforms were no triumph but just the manifestation of a movement within Estado Novo.[17]

These reforms would mostly aim for “economic development, approximation with Europe or a better social justice”[18]. With the cooperation of the new members, more open to reforms, Marcello, started with a revision of the constitution, where several laws were changed: The Electoral Law that would provide more «freedom» and transparency to the voters (1968); the Union Laws that would allow its borders to be elected without the necessity of the approval

[13] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p.697).
[14] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.487).
[15] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. Esfera dos Livros. (p.696).
[16] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa.
[17] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.485).
[18] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa.

from the government, this would incentivise the “collective labour agreements”; the Law of Religious Freedom, which stated that no discrimination could be made due to one’s religious beliefs (1970); the Law of the Press, that guaranteed more freedoms to the press (1972) and the Industiral Promotion Law, that would minimize the tariff barriers that would give the chance for the Portugal businesses to more fairly compete in the foreign market.[19]

Furthermore, regarding the “possible freedoms”[20] Marcello did, according to Rosas, only superficial changes: the name of the Political Police (PIDE) was changed to DGS (General Directorate of Security) and its powers were slightly limited and there was a mild softening of the censorship.[21]

The most substantial reforms were made due to the legislative elections of October 1969. These reforms consisted in extend the suffrage to all literate woman, legalize the political organisms formed by the opposition, allow the consultation of the census books, enable the monitorization of the voting tables, and soften the censorship[22]. These elections were aiming to acquire the most precise opinion of the people, regarding his reforms[23] and more importantly regarding his strategy of applying these reforms while continuing the war, that for Rosas seem as contradictory objectives[24].

Despite the extension of the suffrage, “the electorate remained small”[25]. Nevertheless, the opposition, divided in two main parties, CDE (Communists) and the CEUD (Socialists), lost.

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[19] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p. 700).
[20] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.486).
[21] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p. 486).
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[23] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p.696).
[24] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.486).
[25] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p.697).

These reforms would eventually lead to several problems, “half opened the lid of the pressure cooker, an avalanche of expectation, revindications and desire for changing was expressed.”[26], after this election several strikes emerged especially in the universities, and in important industries. In response, Marcello withdrew the reforms, the Union Law for instance, was revised and changed. In addition, in order to repress the strikes, the political Police regained its role and the censorship was intensified. Nevertheless, Rosas holds that Marcello was gradually losing support of every group society. The liberals that once supported him and his policies, recognized that further democratization would not occur, joined the opposition[27]. The Ultras (now debilitated) that once supported the regime believed that it had become too democratic, and were even planning a «coup d’état», which never occurred.[28] The soldiers and the people were tired of the war[29]. Estado Novo was shaking.

Ramos agrees that the opposition was becoming stronger in the society, and that the Liberals were becoming firm criticizers of the regime[30]. Nevertheless, Ramos believes that no one could predict until 1973 the fall of the regime, given that “life had never been so good in Portugal, with plain job, with full employment, wage rises and expansion of the social States.”[31]. Moreover, he also believed that the opposition, although growing, was still weak, and the situation in the colonies was not dramatic[32]. Everything seemed to have returned to normal and

[26] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.489).
[27] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p.492).
[28] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p. 492).
[29] Rosas, F. (1997). História de Portugal: Estado Novo. Estampa. (p. 492/ 493).
[30] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p.702).
[31] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p.704).
[32] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p. 704).

apathy reigned once again[33].

With the viewpoints of both authors laid out, one can understand, that they both agree that the reforms, in fact weaken Estado Novo. Nevertheless, they differ on the extent to which they have weakened it.

While, Rosas, states that, the reforms had a devastating effect and were in the long term a destabilizing factor for Estado Novo, for the reforms, while giving space to the opposition to arise, also lost the almost immutable support of the Ultras for the regime, that was so precious to Estado Novo to stay alive, and the support of the Liberals that were the “gate keepers” of the reforms.

Ramos, on the other hand, although he believes that the reforms gave space to the opposition to grow and lost the support of some factions of the regime, he also believes that Estado Novo was able to regain some of the strength and support lost. Thus, the damage was not so critical.

Summarizing, Ramos tends to diminish the effects of the reforms, on Estado Novo, and Rosas, believes that this, were a long-term destabiliser for the regime.

In my opinion, while I believe that Marcello made the reforms to regain the once lost support of the Catholics and middle class, and acquire a new field of supporters, the Liberals. He did not think on the consequences of a rapid opening, such as weakening the censorship, which led to the growth of the opposition and loss of support from the Ultras, the regime’s foundations. Furthermore, the abrupt withdrew of the reforms, made him lose the support of

[33] Ramos, R. (2015). História de Portugal. A Esfera dos Livros. (p. 704).

the liberals. Furthermore, by doing this Marcello showed that the reforms were the cause of the chaos, thus the factor that weaken the regime. Therefore, I believe that the reforms, and all the procedures of Marcello regarding them, in fact weaken and accelerated the fall of a regime, that in the long term was set to failure.

Section 3: Reflection

Due to this investigation, I was able to walk in the historians' shoes, which made me aware of the joys and challenges faced by them. I was also able to use and explore the methodology used by the professionals, which consisted of evaluating a source's value and limitation to my investigation, then carefully analyse the two most important and discover the historians' perspective on this specific subject and finally develop my investigation and write it. I really enjoyed this process, nevertheless, I faced some challenges, first I discovered that history books take a long time to analyse as every word mattered and carried a specific purpose, there was no unnecessary "chaff", I had to reread almost every page of the chapters that I selected to analyse, in order to «absorb» every word, for instance. Secondly, neither Rosas nor Ramos addressed the topic directly, thus, they did not give me a direct answer to my question, nevertheless, this gave me the opportunity to reach my own conclusion with the evidence that they gave me. These challenges offered me a new perspective about the historians' work, and enhanced my ability to solve, and overcome problems.

In this investigation I also understanded that every source is permeable to bias especially a secondary one, as these sources are the analyse (or interpretation) of a historian of one or several primary sources. Nevertheless, I tried to evaluate these sources unbiasedly (although some bias will always occur), by putting a side my preconceptions about the topic, and avoided using too many adjectives.

Finally, I enjoyed developing this investigation, as it gave me the opportunity to make a serious investigation to a topic that I wanted to study for a long time. Moreover, the process of evaluating the value of the sources by its purpose, origin, and content, changed the way I address and take other sources of information for my daily life and to future studies and investigations.

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